

Capital Expenditure Analysis

Chesterfield County Public Schools: Estimated vs. Actual Construction Costs
(2020-2026)

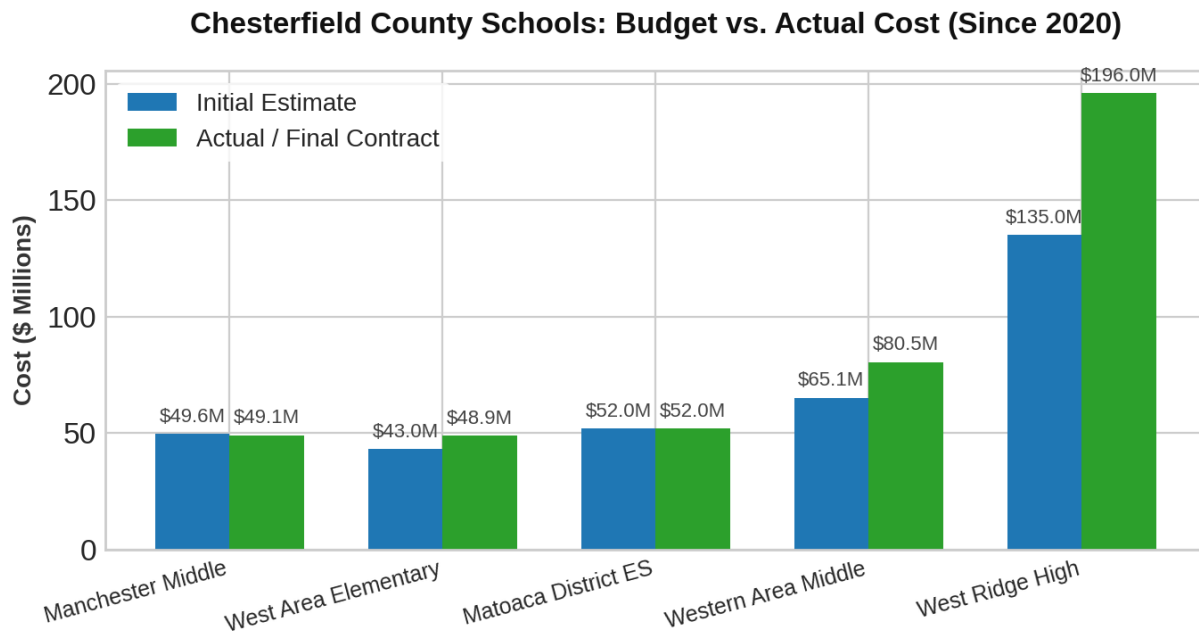
Executive Summary

An analysis of Chesterfield County Public Schools (CCPS) school construction projects reveals a stark divergence between projects planned before vs. after the massive supply chain disruptions of 2020–2022. While the county has successfully delivered its projects on schedule, macro-inflationary forces forced mid-cycle adjustments that broke initial ballot expectations on several landmark projects. The total initial projected capital for these five major builds was **\$344.7 million**, but the cumulative cost escalated to **\$426.5 million**, presenting a net funding gap of **\$81.8 million (23.7% increase)**.

Project Cost Variance Breakdown

Project Name	School Type	Initial Estimate	Actual / Final	Dollar Variance	% Variance
Manchester Middle	Middle	\$49.6M	\$49.1M	-\$0.5M	-1.01%
West Area Elementary	Elementary	\$43.0M	\$48.9M	+\$5.9M	+13.72%
Matoaca District ES	Elementary	\$52.0M	\$52.0M	\$0.0M	0.00%
Western Area Middle	Middle	\$65.1M	\$80.5M	+\$15.4M	+23.66%
West Ridge High	High	\$135.0M	\$196.0M	+\$61.0M	+45.19%

Visual Cost Comparison Chart



Key Budget Drivers & Trends

- **High Schools Face the Greatest Fiscal Volatility:** High schools have exponentially complex infrastructure compared to elementary or middle schools. West Ridge High experienced a massive 45.19% budget expansion (a \$61 million surge). This was fueled directly by spiking costs for structural steel, advanced HVAC installations, and extensive grading requirements across its 120-acre Duval Road site.
- **Prototype Standardizing Anchors Costs:** The 0% variance for Matoaca District Elementary and the minimal overrun for West Area Elementary highlight the success of CCPS's architectural prototype strategy. By utilizing standard two-story templates (built for 1,000 students), the county bypassed unique architectural design fees, streamlined procurement, and optimized materials pricing.
- **Pre- vs. Post-Pandemic Divergence:** Manchester Middle School represents the tail-end of pre-pandemic pricing. It closed under budget due to strict value engineering. Conversely, any project bid after 2022 faced severe market premiums for concrete, electrical hardware, and labor, resulting in double-digit percentage overruns.

Structural Analysis of Cost Adjustments

Rather than abandoning projects or reducing classroom capacities, Chesterfield County leveraged three strategic avenues to balance the budget deficit:

- 1. ARPA Funds Allocation:** The county reallocated multi-million dollar portions of federal American Rescue Plan Act (ARPA) grants directly into the construction fund to blunt material price spikes.
- 2. Capital Reserves:** General fund surpluses and capital reserves were pulled forward to insulate elementary school bids.
- 3. Triple-AAA Debt Maximization:** Chesterfield used its premium credit rating to command low-interest General Obligation bonds, resulting in millions in debt-service savings that offset raw construction deficits.